# American Mahjong

THE COMPLETE BEGINNER'S GUIDE

*Everything you need to know — from your very first tile to calling "Mahjong!" at the table.*

## 📋 Table of Contents


1. What Is American Mahjong?
2. The Equipment
3. The Tiles — Know Your Set
4. Setting Up the Game
5. The Charleston & The Deal
6. How to Play — Turn by Turn
7. Calling Tiles — Pung, Kong, Chow & Mahjong
8. The National Mah Jongg League Card
9. Winning Hands
10. Scoring & Payment
11. Table Etiquette
12. Glossary of Terms
13. Tips for Beginners
14. Common Beginner Mistakes
15. How to Read the NMJL Card
16. Play-By-Play Sample Hand
17. What Should I Discard? — Decision Guide
18. Frequently Asked Questions
19. Quick-Reference Cheat Sheet

# 1 What Is American Mahjong? 🀄

**American Mahjong** (also spelled Mah Jongg or Mah Jong) is a tile-based game played by **4 players** around a table. It combines strategy, memory, skill, and a little luck — think of it as a cross between rummy and poker, but played with beautiful tiles instead of cards.

Originally from China, the game was brought to America in the 1920s and became enormously popular. The **National Mah Jongg League (NMJL)**, founded in 1937, standardized American rules and publishes a new official card every year listing the legal winning hands. Today millions of Americans play it, particularly popular at kitchens, clubs, and community centers.

The goal: be the first player to complete a legal winning hand by drawing and trading tiles, then shout **"Mahjong!"**

👥

## Players

4 players. You can play with 3 in a pinch (one hand dealt face-down as a "dummy"), but 4 is standard.

⏱️

## Game Length

Each hand takes about 10–20 minutes. A full game is typically 4 rounds (East, South, West, North), though many groups play just until tiles run out.

🧠

## Skill Level

Beginner-friendly but deep. It takes one session to learn, and years to master. Even newcomers can win!

### Scoring

Played with poker chips. Winners collect from losers. American Mahjong is unique — only the winner scores.

## 2 The Equipment

### 152 Tiles

- 36 Bamboo tiles (1–9, ×4)
- 36 Character tiles (1–9, ×4)
- 36 Dot/Circle tiles (1–9, ×4)
- 16 Wind tiles (×4 each)
- 12 Dragon tiles (×4 each)
- 8 Flower tiles (×1 each, unique)
- 8 Jokers (wild cards!) ×2 sets

### Racks

4 wooden or plastic racks to hold and display your tiles upright, hidden from other players.

### 2 Dice

Used to determine the direction of the deal and which player breaks the wall first.

🃏

### NMJL Card

The official card listing all legal winning hands for the current year. *Each player needs one.*

💵

### Poker Chips

For scoring and payment. Typically each player starts with $1 in chips (in pennies, nickels, dimes).

🪟

### Pusher / Bettor

Optional: a small flat tool to push tiles neatly. Some sets include a bettor for bets on the side.

💡 **Tip:** American Mahjong sets come in small (144 tile) and full (152+ tile) versions. Make sure your set includes **8 Jokers** — this is unique to American Mahjong and essential for the game!

## 3 The Tiles — Know Your Set 🎴

There are **6 categories** of tiles. The three numbered suits form the backbone of most hands. Hover over any tile below to see it lift!

## 🀄 THE THREE NUMBER SUITS

CHARACTERS (CRACKS) — 1 THROUGH 9 — CHINESE NUMERALS ON A RED/ORANGE BACKGROUND

DOTS (CIRCLES / BALLS) — 1 THROUGH 9 — CIRCLES ARRANGED ON THE TILE

BAMBOO (BAMS) — 1 THROUGH 9 — BAMBOO STALKS (THE 1-BAMBOO USUALLY SHOWS A BIRD)

## 🀀 HONOR TILES & SPECIAL TILES

WINDS — EAST 🀀 SOUTH 🀁 WEST 🀂 NORTH 🀃

DRAGONS — RED (中 CHUN) GREEN (發 FA) WHITE (白 BAI)

FLOWERS — 8 UNIQUE SEASONAL/FLOWER TILES, EACH APPEARS ONLY ONCE

## ⭐ JOKERS — The American Mahjong Wild Card

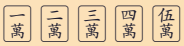
J J J J J J J J

8 JOKERS — CAN SUBSTITUTE FOR ANY TILE IN A SET OF 3 OR MORE OF THE SAME TILE (A "GROUP"). JOKERS CANNOT BE USED IN PAIRS AND CAN BE "EXCHANGED" BY OTHER PLAYERS MID-GAME!

### Bamboo 🎋

Numbers 1–9. Tiles show bamboo stalks. Often called "Bams." The 1-Bam is special — it shows a bird or peacock.

### Characters 🈶

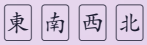



Numbers 1–9 written in Chinese characters. Often called "Cracks." Bright red/orange design.

### Dots 🔵

Numbers 1–9. Circles arranged to show the number. Also called "Balls" or "Circles."

### Winds 🌬️




East, South, West, North. 4 tiles of each direction = 16 wind tiles total. Used in many winning hands.

### Dragons 🐉

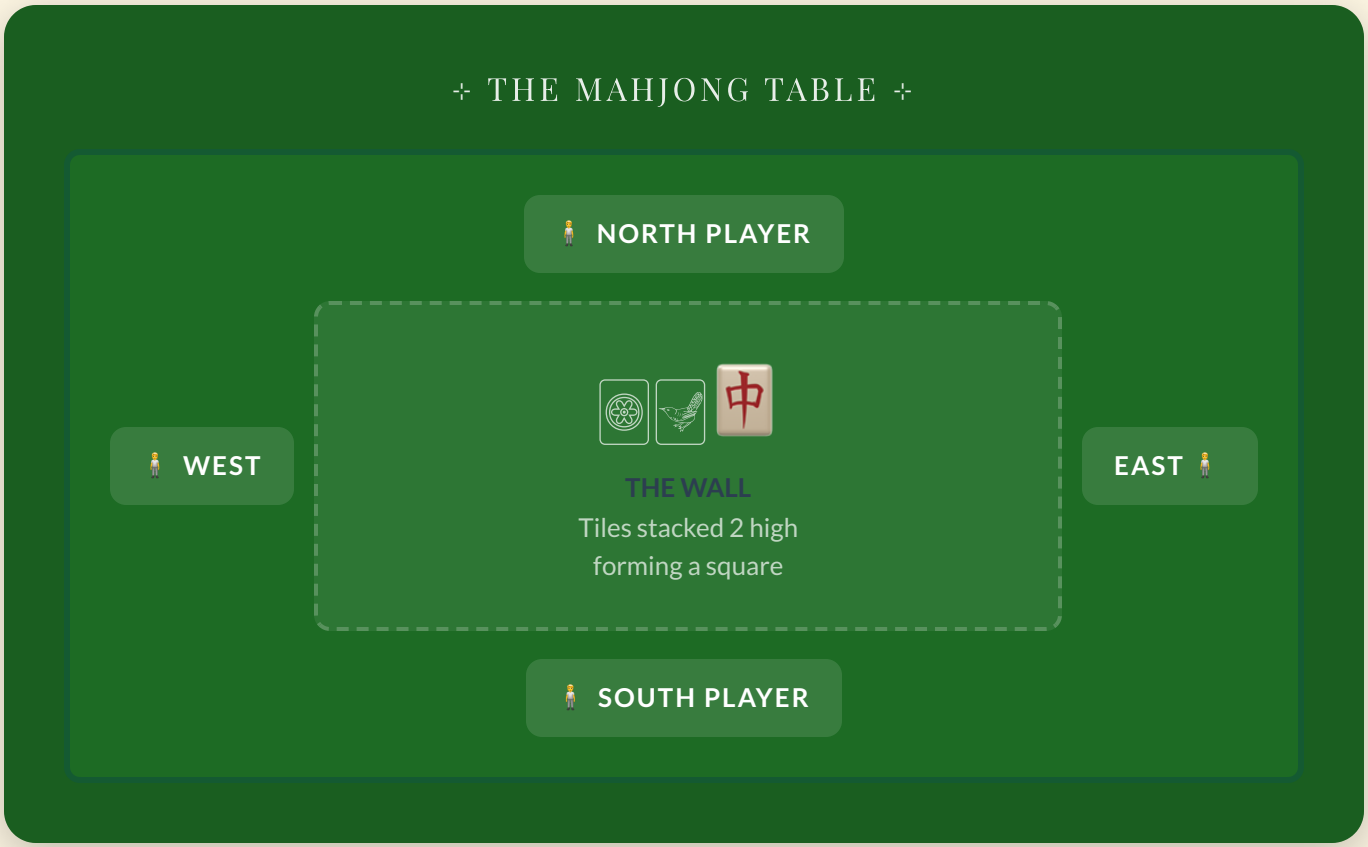
Red Dragon (中), Green Dragon (發), White Dragon (白). 4 of each = 12 total. High value tiles.

### Flowers 🌸

8 unique flowers. Only 1 of each. Used in special flower hands. Very valuable when they appear!

## 4 Setting Up the Game 🏗️

Before the first tile is drawn, the table needs to be set up properly.




### 1 Mix the Tiles ("Washing")

Turn all 152 tiles face-down on the table. All players mix them together with their hands — the sound is part of the experience! Mix for about 30 seconds.

### 2 Build the Wall

Each player pushes tiles toward themselves and builds a row of tiles stacked **2 high and 19 wide** (38 tiles per side), facing inward. The four rows form a square wall in the center of the table.

3

### Determine East (the Dealer)

Each player rolls the dice. The **highest roller** becomes East — the first dealer. East is the most important seat as it deals first and wins/loses double.

4

### Assign Seats

Seats go clockwise: East, South, West, North. After each hand, the deal passes to the right (so East moves one seat clockwise).

5

### Break the Wall

East rolls the dice again. Count that many tiles along their own section of the wall, and break it at that point. Dealing begins from the right side of the break, going clockwise.

## 5 The Deal & The Charleston 🔄

### The Deal

Tiles are dealt in groups of 4, going clockwise around the table, until each player has **13 tiles**. East then draws one extra tile, giving East **14 tiles** to start.

Stand your tiles on your rack, hidden from other players. Look at your tiles and compare them to your NMJL card to start thinking about what hand you want to build.

> ⚠️ **Important:** Don't show your tiles to other players! Your rack is your shield. Keep tiles hidden at all times (except when you make a called set, which is placed face-up).

### The Charleston — Trading Before Play Begins

The Charleston is **unique to American Mahjong**. Before gameplay begins, players pass unwanted tiles to neighbors, helping everyone build toward a good hand. There are up to **3 rounds** of passing:

➡️

#### First Right

Pass **3 tiles face-down** to the player on your right simultaneously. All players pass at the same time.

⬆️

### First Across

Pass **3 tiles face-down** to the player sitting directly across from you simultaneously.

⬅️

### First Left

Pass **3 tiles face-down** to the player on your left simultaneously.

🔄

### Second Charleston

*Optional* — only if ALL players agree. Repeat the process: right, across, left. Even if agreed, each player can opt out of the final left pass.

🤝

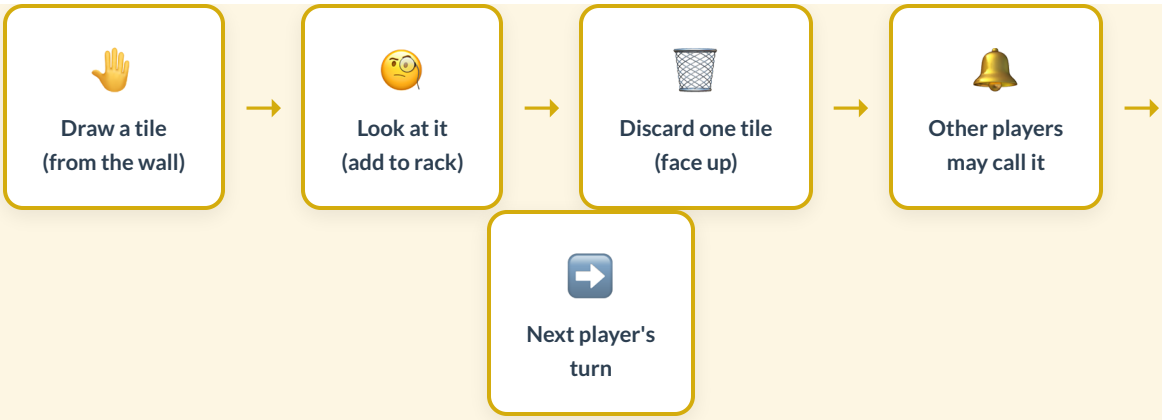
### Optional Pass

After all Charlestons, players may offer **1–3 tiles** to the player across from them ("courtesy pass"). The across player may accept some, all, or none.

> 💡 **Strategy Tip:** Pass tiles that don't fit ANY of your potential hands. Never pass tiles you might need — and be strategic about what you send in each direction!

## 6 How to Play — Turn by Turn ▶️

After the Charleston, gameplay begins with **East** discarding one tile. Play then proceeds **counterclockwise** (to East's right).




### 1 Draw From the Wall

On your turn, take the next tile from the **right end of the wall**. Add it to your hand (now you have 14 tiles). Look at your NMJL card — does this complete your hand?

### 2 Decide & Discard

Choose one tile you don't need and **place it face-up in the center** of the table (the "discard pile"). Say the tile name aloud — e.g., "Three Bam!" This is important — others need to hear it.

### 3 Other Players React

Any other player may **call that discarded tile** to complete a set — but only if the tile completes a valid set *toward their winning hand*. Calling rules vary (see Section 7).

### 4 If Nobody Calls...

The next player draws from the wall and play continues. Once a new tile is drawn from the wall, the previous discard is **dead** — it cannot be claimed.

> ⚠️ **Key Rule:** In American Mahjong, you can only pick up a discarded tile if it completes a *set of 3 or more identical tiles* (a pung, kong, or quint) — **or if it completes your winning hand (Mahjong)**. You generally CANNOT pick up a discard to complete a run (sequence).

## 7 Calling Tiles — Pung, Kong, Chow & Mahjong 📣

When another player discards a tile you need, you may "call" it — but you must do so **before the next player draws from the wall**. Saying the right word is key!

## PUNG! 🀡🀡🀡

🀡 🀡 🀡

**3 identical tiles.** You have 2 of a tile; someone discards the 3rd. Call "Pung!" — take the tile, lay the set face-up on your rack, then discard.

## KONG! 🀢🀢🀢🀢

🀢 🀢 🀢 🀢

**4 identical tiles.** You have 3 tiles; someone discards the 4th. Call "Kong!" — take it, lay all 4 face-up, discard. (Or draw from wall to make a kong from 4 in-hand.)

## Sequence — Rare!

🀢 🀣 🀤

**In American Mahjong, claiming a discard to complete a sequence (run) is NOT standard** unless the card specifically requires it. Focus on pungs and kongs.

## MAHJONG! 🏆

🀄 🀅 🀡 🀡

**You win!** Call "Mahjong!" when any discard (or your draw) completes your full winning hand. Lay all tiles face-up and collect your winnings!

### ⭐ The Joker Exchange Rule

If another player has a **Joker displayed face-up** in an exposed set, and you have the *exact tile that the Joker is substituting*, you may swap it on your turn:

1. Wait until it's your turn to draw from the wall.
2. Place your matching tile into their exposed set and take the Joker into your own hand.

3 Then draw from the wall as normal (this exchange does NOT replace your draw).

You may only exchange for the Joker *before* you draw from the wall.

## 8 The National Mah Jongg League Card

The **NMJL Card** is the heart of American Mahjong. Published every year (usually in March), it lists all the *legal winning hands* for that year. You **must** match one of these hands exactly to win — you cannot just build "any good hand." Each player has their own card.

The card is laminated and small enough to prop up on your rack. Keep it secret from other players — which hand you're building is your strategy!

### How to Read the Card

| Symbol | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| **2, 4, 6, 8...** | A specific tile number | 2 Bam = the 2 of Bamboo |
| **D** | Dragon (Red, Green, or White) | Depends on hand requirements |
| **N, S, E, W** | North, South, East, West winds | NSEW = all four winds |
| **F** | Flower tile | Any flower tile |
| **Any Suit** | You choose one suit and use it throughout | 1-9 in all Bams or all Dots |
| **Singles & Pairs (S&P)** | Hand made entirely of pairs | No jokers allowed in pairs! |
| **X (closed)** | Must be built entirely from draws — no called tiles | Worth more money |
| **$** | Worth double payment | Special/rare hands |

### Card Sections (Typical)

🔢

### 2024 / Year Hands

Hands using the current year's digits (e.g., 2-0-2-4). These change each year!

🌸

### Flower Hands

Hands that incorporate flower tiles. Flowers are very useful here.

🔢

### Consecutive Run

Hands built on sequential tiles (1-2-3, 2-3-4, etc.) across same or different suits.

🎭

### Odd & Even

Hands using only odd (1,3,5,7,9) or even (2,4,6,8) numbered tiles.

🃏

### Singles & Pairs

The most unique section — pairs only, NO jokers allowed. Tests pure tile luck and skill.

### Winds & Dragons

Hands heavy on honor tiles — winds and dragons. Can be very valuable.

## 9 Winning Hands — Examples

A winning hand consists of exactly **14 tiles** arranged to match one complete hand on the NMJL card. Here are examples of the types of hands you might see:

### Consecutive Run

Three pungs of 1-2-3 Bam plus a pair of 4 Bam. "111 222 333 44" in one suit.

### Winds & Dragons

Pungs of all four winds plus a Red Dragon pair. Pure honor tile hand!

### Singles & Pairs

Seven different pairs. NO jokers allowed here — pure tiles only!

### Odd Numbers Run

A pair of 1s, pungs of 3s, 5s, 7s, and a pair of 9s — all odd numbers, one suit.

### Year Hand (2025)

Uses the digits 2, 0, 2, 5 built into tile groupings. Changes every year!

### Flower Hand

All 8 flowers plus two pungs. Flowers are wild in certain flower-hand positions.

💡 **Rule:** A completed hand must have exactly **14 tiles**. You can use **Jokers in any set of 3 or more identical tiles**, but **never in pairs** (including the "singles & pairs" section on the card).

## 10 Scoring & Payment 💰

In American Mahjong, **only the winner scores**. Losers pay the winner. Payment is based on the *value listed on the NMJL card* next to the winning hand, and *how the winner got their last tile*.

**Self-Drawn Win**

**×2**

If you draw your winning tile yourself from the wall — ALL three other players pay you double the hand value.

**Win on a Discard**

**×1**

If another player discards your winning tile — only *that player* pays you the hand value.

💵

**Double Hands**

Hands marked with "$" on the card are worth double. Both payment rules above still apply.

🙅

**Dead Hand Penalty**

If a player's hand is "dead" (impossible to win), they must pay all three other players the value of the highest hand on the card!

### Typical Hand Values (Approximate)

| Hand Type | Approximate Value |
|---|---|
| Regular hand | 25¢ |
| Singles & Pairs | 50¢ |
| Double hand ($) | 50¢ or $1.00 |
| Dead hand penalty | Pay highest hand value to each player |

> ⚠️ **Dead Hand:** A hand becomes "dead" if you expose a tile that makes it *impossible* to complete any legal hand on the card — for example, calling a pung but then realizing you can't complete any valid hand. Once dead, you must *continue playing* (so others don't know), but you'll owe each player at game's end.

## 11 Table Etiquette 🤝

Mahjong has a strong social tradition. Follow these unwritten rules and you'll be a welcome player anywhere.

📢 **Don't discuss your hand.** Never hint at what you're building. Saying "I need one more!" tells your opponents too much.

⏱️ **Don't stall.** Once you decide to call a tile, call it promptly. Hesitating and then calling is poor form.

🗣️ **Say the tile aloud when discarding.** Name your discard clearly — "Five Dot!" — so every player hears it.

👁️ **Watch for Joker exchanges.** If you have a tile that matches a Joker in someone's exposed set, you can take that Joker. Don't forget!

🚫 **Don't peek at others' racks.** This is cheating. Keep your eyes on your own tiles and the center.

💬 **Ask before the game starts, not during.** If you have a rules question, ask before play begins or between hands.

🤫 **Don't give advice during a hand.** Even if you see someone making a mistake — stay quiet until the hand is over.

📱 **Put your phone away.** Be present! Mahjong is a social game. Distracted players slow everyone down.

🏆 **Declare Mahjong promptly.** Once you complete your hand, say "Mahjong!" immediately. Don't wait and keep drawing.

🎉 **Be a gracious winner and loser.** Mahjong has luck involved. Congratulate winners and don't complain about bad draws.

## 12 Glossary of Terms 📖

### Bamboo (Bams)

The green suit; tiles numbered 1–9 with bamboo stalks.

### Charleston

The pre-game tile passing ritual (right, across, left).

### Characters (Cracks)

The red/orange suit; tiles numbered 1–9 with Chinese characters.

### Dead Hand

A hand that can no longer win; incurs a penalty.

### Discard

A tile placed face-up in the center, available for others to call.

### Dots (Circles/Balls)

The blue suit; tiles numbered 1–9 with circles.

### Dragons

Honor tiles — Red (中), Green (發), White (白). 4 of each.

### East

The dealer seat; deals first and wins/loses double.

### Flowers

8 unique decorative tiles; each appears only once in the set.

### Joker

Wild card; can substitute for any tile in a group of 3+.

### Joker Exchange

Swapping one of your tiles for a Joker in an exposed set.

### Kong

A set of 4 identical tiles. Called when you need the 4th.

### Mahjong!

The winning call; shouted when your hand is complete.

### NMJL Card

The National Mah Jongg League card listing legal winning hands.

### Pung

A set of 3 identical tiles. The most common set in American Mah Jongg.

### Quint

A set of 5 identical tiles (4 + 1 Joker, or all with Jokers).

### Rack

The holder that displays your tiles upright.

### Self-Draw

Drawing your winning tile from the wall (worth double).

### Singles & Pairs

Card section; hands made of pairs only, no Jokers allowed.

### The Wall

The rectangular formation of tiles built at game start.

### Washing

Mixing tiles face-down before building the wall.

### Winds

Honor tiles — East, South, West, North. 4 of each.

## 13 Tips for Beginners ⭐

🎯

### Pick 2–3 Hands per Deal

Don't try to keep every option open. After the Charleston, commit to 2–3 candidate hands on the card and build toward them.

🔍

### Study the Card Before Playing

Read the NMJL card before your first game. Familiarity with hand shapes is your biggest advantage.

🀄

### Love Your Jokers

Jokers are incredibly powerful. Don't pass them in the Charleston (unless you're desperate). They unlock harder hands.

👀

### Watch What Others Discard

The discard pile tells you what others DON'T need — and hints at what hands they may be building. Avoid feeding opponents tiles they need.

### Change Plans Mid-Game

Be flexible! If your tiles don't come and a new hand becomes possible, switch strategies. Rigidity loses games.

### Singles & Pairs = No Jokers

If you have great pairs but no Jokers, aim for a Singles & Pairs hand. They're often the most achievable naturally.

### Defense Matters

If someone calls multiple tiles, they're getting close to winning. Start discarding "safe" tiles — ones already discarded (so they can't complete a set of 4).

### Don't Fear Dead Hands

Beginners fear dead hands, but they're rare if you pay attention. Just make sure every time you call a tile, your hand can still reach a legal card hand.

### The Best Way to Learn?

**Just play.** It takes about 3 games for the rules to click. By game 5, you'll be strategizing. By game 10, you'll be addicted!

🌟 **Final Thought:** American Mahjong is as much about socializing as winning. The conversations, the groans at bad draws, the cheers at a self-drawn Mahjong — that's what makes it a beloved tradition. Welcome to the table!

## 14 Common Beginner Mistakes 🚨

Everyone makes these mistakes their first few games. Read this now and you'll be ahead of the curve!

🃏

### Using a Joker in a Pair

Jokers can only substitute for tiles in groups of **3 or more identical tiles** (pungs, kongs, quints). They are *never* allowed in pairs — not even in Singles & Pairs hands.

**Fix:** Before placing a Joker, count how many tiles are in that set. If it's only 2, you cannot use a Joker there.

📤

### Passing a Joker in the Charleston

Beginners often pass Jokers because they "don't know what to do with them yet." This is a huge mistake — Jokers are the most valuable tiles in the game.

**Fix:** *Never* pass a Joker in the Charleston unless you have 3+ Jokers and genuinely cannot use them all.

🛑

### Calling a Tile Without Checking Your Hand First

You see a tile you need and shout "Pung!" — then realize it makes your hand dead because the resulting hand doesn't match any card combination. This is the most common way to end up with a dead hand.

**Fix:** Before calling ANY tile, mentally check: "If I take this tile and expose it, can I still complete a valid hand on my card?"

🤫

### Forgetting to Call "Mahjong!"

You draw or get discarded the tile that completes your hand — and you forget to declare it! Once the next player draws from the wall, your winning moment is gone.

**Fix:** The moment you complete your hand, say "Mahjong!" immediately and clearly. Don't wait even one second.

### Trying to Play Too Many Hands at Once

Keeping 6 different hand options open as the game progresses means you never get close to completing any of them. Flexibility is good; indecision is deadly.

**Fix:** After the Charleston, narrow down to your top 2 hands. After 5–6 draws, commit to 1 primary hand.

### Forgetting You Can Exchange a Joker

If another player has a Joker displayed in their exposed set, and you have the exact tile it's standing in for, you can swap it on your turn — before drawing. Beginners routinely miss this opportunity.

**Fix:** At the start of every turn, scan all exposed sets for Jokers before drawing from the wall.

### Not Announcing Discards Aloud

Quietly sliding a tile to the center means other players may miss a tile they need, or may not realize you discarded. This slows the game and causes disputes.

**Fix:** Say the tile name clearly every time — "Four Dot!", "West Wind!", "Red Dragon!" — before releasing it.

### Declaring Mahjong With an Incorrect Hand

Calling Mahjong when your tiles don't actually match a valid hand on the card — this is an automatic penalty. You must pay each other player the highest hand value on the card.

**Fix:** Before calling Mahjong, double-check tile by tile against your card. When in doubt, keep playing!

## 15 How to Read the NMJL Card — Annotated

The NMJL card looks intimidating at first, but once you know the code it becomes second nature. Below is a **mock card section** with annotations explaining every part.

## ★ SAMPLE NMJL CARD SECTION — "2025" ★

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| `FF 2025 2025` | 25¢ | **FF** = 2 flower tiles \| **2025** = tiles numbered 2, 0 (white dragon), 2, 5 — repeated twice as pungs/pairs |
| `NEWS NEWS NNEE` | 25¢ | **N E W S** = North, East, West, South winds — pungs of each pair of winds + a pair |
| `111 222 333 44` *(any suit)* | 25¢ | Three pungs (111, 222, 333) + one pair (44) all in the **same suit**. You pick which suit. |
| `11 222 333 444 X` | 50¢ | **X = CLOSED hand** — you cannot call any discarded tiles. Must build entirely from your own draws. Worth double! |
| `FF GGG RRR WW $` | $1.00 | **$ = Double value.** **G** = Green Dragon, **R** = Red Dragon, **W** = White Dragon (or West Wind — context determines). Very rare, very rewarding! |
| `11 33 55 77 99` *(S&P)* | 50¢ | **S&P = Singles & Pairs section.** Hand made of pairs only. **NO JOKERS ALLOWED** in any tile in this section. |

### Symbol Quick-Key

| Symbol | Meaning | Notes |
|---|---|---|
| **F** | Any Flower tile | 8 unique flowers in the set |
| **N / S / E / W** | North / South / East / West wind | Can mix winds unless hand specifies |
| **G / R / W(D)** | Green / Red / White Dragon | W = White Dragon (not West Wind) in dragon context |
| **Numbers (1–9)** | Tile of that number | Suit specified by "any suit" or explicitly named |
| **0** | Zero = White Dragon (blank tile) | Used in year hands (2025 etc.) |
| **X** | Closed hand — no called discards | Worth double payment |

| Symbol | Meaning | Notes |
|---|---|---|
| **$** | Double payment hand | Rare and valuable |
| **S&P** | Singles & Pairs section | Pairs only, zero Jokers |
| **Any suit** | You choose one suit and use it consistently | Cannot mix suits within a hand (unless card says so) |

💡 **Tip:** Before each game, quickly scan all the sections of the card and pick 3–4 hands that appeal to you based on your drawn tiles. Having a "shortlist" before the Charleston makes passing decisions much faster.

## 16 Play-By-Play: A Sample Hand 🎬

Let's follow **Sara** through a complete hand — from the deal to Mahjong! She's going for the hand:

```
111 222 333 44  (all Bam)
```

Three pungs of 1, 2, and 3 Bamboo, plus a pair of 4 Bamboo — 14 tiles total.

**DEALT**

### Sara's Starting 13 Tiles

She has: two 1-Bams, three 2-Bams, two 3-Bams, two 4-Bams — a solid start toward her target hand! She also has some junk: Green Dragon, East Wind, 9-Dot, 5-Crack.

**CHARLESTON**

### Sara Passes Her Junk

She passes **Green Dragon, East Wind, 9-Dot** to the right — tiles she has no use for. She receives back three tiles: 6-Crack, 7-Bam, and a **Joker**! She keeps the Joker (gold!), discards the 6-Crack and 5-Crack over the next passes.

TURN 1

### Sara Draws from the Wall

She draws a **3-Bam**! Now she has three 3-Bams. That's a pung! She doesn't need the 7-Bam.

Discards: 7-Bam

TURN 3

### Someone Discards 1-Bam!

The player to Sara's left discards a 1-Bam. Sara already has two 1-Bams — this would give her a pung of three!

**Sara calls: "Pung!"** — She takes the 1-Bam, lays her three 1-Bams face-up on her rack, and discards her least useful tile.

Discards: 9-Bam (she doesn't need it)

TURN 5

### Sara Draws a 2-Bam

She now has *four* 2-Bams — that's a Kong. But wait, her card hand only calls for a pung (3). She uses her **Joker** to replace one 2-Bam she doesn't need, keeping 3 natural 2-Bams as her pung. She discards the extra 2-Bam.

Discards: 2-Bam (her 4th one)

TURN 7

### Joker Exchange Opportunity!

Sara notices that another player has an exposed pung of 3-Bam with a Joker in it. Sara has a natural 3-Bam in her hand — she can swap it for their Joker!

She places her 3-Bam tile into their set and takes the Joker. Now she has 2 Jokers. Then she draws from the wall as normal.

TURN 9

### Sara Needs One More: a 4-Bam

She has: **(pung, exposed) + (pung) + (pung) + + Joker**

She uses the Joker as her second 4-Bam for the pair — she just needs ONE real 4-Bam to complete the hand. She already has one natural 4-Bam.

**She is ONE tile away from Mahjong!**

TURN 11

🏆 **MAHJONG!**

The player across from Sara discards a **4-Bam**. Sara has her second natural 4-Bam — her pair is complete!

🀋🀋 — **The pair is complete! MAHJONG!**

Sara lays all 14 tiles face-up. She wins on a discard — so *only the player who discarded the 4-Bam pays her* the hand value (25¢). If she had drawn it herself, all three players would have paid her 50¢ each.

💡 **Key Takeaways from This Hand:** Sara committed to one hand early, passed her junk in the Charleston, called a Pung when the opportunity arose, executed a Joker exchange, and used Jokers strategically. She stayed flexible but stayed focused!

## 17 What Should I Discard? — Decision Guide 🤔

Deciding what to throw away is the core skill of Mahjong. Use this guide every turn until it becomes instinct.

### Step-by-Step Decision Tree

**Does this tile appear in ANY of my target hands on the card?**

- YES: Keep it — do not discard
- NO: It's a candidate for discard ↓

**Is this tile already in the discard pile? (a "safe" tile)**

- YES: Safe to discard — others likely can't complete a set of 4
- NO: Risky — could help an opponent ↓

**Has anyone called this tile already? (means 3 are accounted for)**

| YES | NO |
| --- | --- |
| Safe — no one can use a 4th | Use your best judgement — discard if you must |

### Discard Priority Rules (in order)

| Priority | What to Discard | Why |
| --- | --- | --- |
| **1st** | Tiles not in ANY target hand | Zero value to you — get rid of them first |
| **2nd** | Tiles already in the discard pile | "Safe" discards — can't complete a 4th set for anyone |
| **3rd** | Honors (winds/dragons) you don't need | Opponents often don't need them either |
| **4th** | Tiles from your weaker backup hand | Time to commit to your primary target |
| **Last Resort** | Tiles your opponents seem to need | Sometimes you must discard dangerous tiles — be strategic |
| **NEVER** | Jokers | Jokers are always useful — hold them until the very end |

⚠️ **Watch the Discards!** Keep an eye on what tiles have been thrown away. Once 3 of a tile are in the discard pile, no one can make a pung of it anymore — making it completely "safe" for you to discard too. This is called "reading the wall."

## 18 Frequently Asked Questions ❓

**Q:** Can I use a Joker in a pair?

**A:** No. Jokers can only be used in sets of 3 or more identical tiles (pungs, kongs, quints). They are never allowed in pairs — not in any section of the card, including Singles & Pairs.

### **Q:** What happens if two people call the same discarded tile?

**A:** The player who is calling "Mahjong!" always wins the tile over any other call. If no one is calling Mahjong, the player whose turn is next in the rotation (counterclockwise) has priority — but only if they can make a valid pung/kong toward a legal hand.

### **Q:** Can I pick up a discarded tile to complete a run (sequence like 3-4-5)?

**A:** No — not in American Mahjong. You can only claim a discard to make a pung (3 identical) or kong (4 identical), or to declare Mahjong. Picking up discards for sequences is a rule in Chinese/Hong Kong Mahjong, not American.

### **Q:** What is a "closed" hand (marked X on the card)?

**A:** A closed hand means you cannot call any discarded tiles during the game — every tile must be drawn by yourself from the wall. You can still win when someone discards your final tile (that doesn't count as "calling"). Closed hands are worth double payment.

### **Q:** Do I have to announce what tiles I'm passing in the Charleston?

**A:** No — all Charleston passes are face-down and secret. You should not show or announce what you're passing. Pass the tiles simultaneously with other players so no one gains information from timing.

### **Q:** What happens when the wall runs out of tiles?

**A:** If no one wins before the last tile is drawn, the hand is declared a "wall game" (or "dead game"). No one wins or loses any money — tiles are re-washed and a new hand is dealt. The same dealer deals again (East does not pass).

### **Q:** Can I change my mind about which hand I'm building?

**A:** Yes — as long as you haven't exposed any tiles (called a pung/kong). Once you expose tiles face-up on your rack, you are locked into any hand that includes those tiles. Before exposure, you can freely switch target hands.

**Q:** What are Flowers used for? Do I have to use them?

**A:** Flowers are used in specific "Flower hands" listed on the NMJL card (e.g., a hand requiring 2 Flowers + pungs). If you're not building a Flower hand, Flowers are essentially useless tiles — discard them early. You are never required to keep them.

**Q:** What's the difference between American and Chinese Mahjong?

**A:** American Mahjong has: Jokers (wild cards), the Charleston pass ritual, the NMJL card with fixed legal hands, and a simpler scoring system where only the winner scores. Chinese/Hong Kong Mahjong has no Jokers, no Charleston, no fixed hand list, and all players score based on their hand value.

**Q:** Can I look at my opponent's discards during the game?

**A:** Yes — all discards are placed face-up in the center and are public information. However, you generally cannot rearrange or re-examine them once other tiles are placed on top. That's why experienced players take a mental note of important discards as they happen.

## 19 Quick-Reference Cheat Sheet 📌

Print this page and keep it next to your rack during your first few games!

# American Mahjong — Cheat Sheet

CUT OUT AND KEEP AT THE TABLE

### The 3 Number Suits

**Bamboo (Bam):** (1–9)

**Dots (Circles):** (1–9)

**Characters (Cracks):** 一萬 二萬 三萬 四萬 伍萬 六萬 七萬 八萬 九萬 (1–9)

## 🀅 Honor & Special Tiles

**Winds:** 🀀 East 🀁 South 🀂 West 🀃 North

**Dragons:** 🀄 Red 🀅 Green 🀆 White

**Flowers:** 8 unique tiles (🀢🀣🀤🀥...)

**Jokers:** 8 wild cards — use in sets of 3+

## 🔔 Calling Tiles

**PUNG:** 3 identical tiles

**KONG:** 4 identical tiles

**MAHJONG:** complete winning hand

Call BEFORE the next player draws!

No calls for runs/sequences

## ⭐ Joker Rules

Substitutes for ANY tile in a set of 3+

NEVER use in pairs

NEVER pass in the Charleston

Can be exchanged from exposed sets

Exchange before drawing from wall

## 💰 Scoring

**Win on discard:** 1 player pays you

**Self-draw win:** ALL 3 players pay double

**$ hand:** double the value

**X (closed) hand:** double value

**Dead hand:** you pay all 3 players!

## 🔄 Charleston Order

**1st:** Pass 3 tiles RIGHT

**2nd:** Pass 3 tiles ACROSS

**3rd:** Pass 3 tiles LEFT

Optional 2nd Charleston if all agree

Optional courtesy pass across at end

## 🃏 Reading the Card

**F** = Flower tile

**N/S/E/W** = Wind tiles

**G/R/W(D)** = Dragons

**0** = White Dragon (zero)

**X** = Closed (no calls)

**$** = Double payment

## 🚨 Never Do This!

Never use Joker in a pair

Never pass a Joker in Charleston

Never call a tile without checking your hand

Never forget to say "Mahjong!" immediately

Never show your tiles to others

**YOUR GOAL:** Be the first to complete a 14-tile hand that exactly matches one hand on the NMJL card — then shout **"MAHJONG!"**

# Happy Playing!

National Mah Jongg League: nationalmahjonggleague.org

Official rules governed by the National Mah Jongg League (NMJL) · New card published annually each spring